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RESEARCH BRIEF — FOR CAREGIVERS

# Gifting AI Learning

A Caregiver's Brief — why giving the gift of calm, self-paced AI learning is different from giving another device

A research brief from mynaani — September 2026

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## Executive summary

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If you care for an older adult, you have probably been the person they call when a device does something unexpected, when a password will not work, or when a new app feels impossible. Technology is already inside their life, and increasingly it mediates health, finance, family, and safety. Yet the tools that matter most are often the hardest for them to learn — not because they cannot, but because those tools were not designed for how older adults learn.

This brief is for the family members, adult children, spouses, and friends who want to give a gift that closes that gap. It synthesizes recent research on family technology support, caregiver technology use, and the particular challenge of helping an older adult become confident with AI. The evidence points to three conclusions:

- Family caregivers are already the primary technology support system for older adults — often in informal, unpaid, and emotionally complex roles.
- Most technology gifts fail because they hand someone a tool and leave them to adapt to it.
- A gift that respects how older adults learn — calm, self-paced, plain-language, cognitively protective — gives the recipient a path from uncertainty to independence.

Mynaani was built on those principles. This brief explains what the research says about the gift you are considering, why it works differently from another gadget or subscription, and how to think about your own role as a supporter.

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## 1. The gap: older adults and AI are not meeting on equal terms

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AI is now part of everyday life. Roughly half of U.S. adults say they use AI chatbots; for adults 65 and older, the picture is different. They are the most uncertain age group about what AI will mean for them, and their adoption

curve is steeper than it looks: older adults are actually the fastest-growing group of AI users, yet the tools they encounter are built for younger, more confident learners (Pew Research Center, 2026; AARP, 2025).

The mismatch is not about interest. AARP's 2025 caregiving technology research found that adults 50 and older who are caregivers are significantly more likely than non-caregivers to have tried generative AI, and are more likely to expect it to be helpful in the next six months. Older adults are reaching for AI. The problem is that the interfaces, explanations, and support systems assume a learner with different eyes, memory, patience, and self-efficacy.

The result: anxiety, avoidance, and dependence on the nearest helper — usually a family member.

## 2. Who is doing the helping

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Family members are the invisible support layer of older adult technology use. In a 2022 CSCW study of older and younger adults in China, Tang and colleagues found that younger family members play four distinct roles over time: **influencers**, **supporters**, **protectors**, and **monitors**. These roles evolve as the older adult's skills and online activity change. The relationship is not one-directional teaching; it is a long-term collaboration with recurring negotiations over autonomy, safety, and competence.

That finding is important for anyone giving a technology gift. You are not just buying a thing; you are entering a support relationship. If the gift requires you to keep stepping in, it has become another task on a list that is already too long.

The time burden is real. The Caregiver Action Network's 2026 Tech Insights Survey of 272 family caregivers found that nearly four in ten (37%) spend 11 or more hours per week on care coordination alone — before any direct hands-on care. Medication and prescription management, scheduling appointments, and communicating with multiple providers are the most time-consuming tasks. Adding "tech support for a new device" to that load is not a small thing.

### 3. Why most technology gifts fall short

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Most technology gifts make the recipient adapt to the tool. The giver assumes the older adult will figure it out, or that the giver will be available to help. The research says both assumptions are risky.

A 2025 study in *Heliyon* of 182 older-adult and family-caregiver pairs found that the older adult's technology use intention is highest when the older adult's own belief about their ability matches the family caregiver's belief. Misfit — when the caregiver thinks the older adult is less capable than the older adult feels, or vice versa — predicts lower use intention. The older adult's own sense of capability matters most. A gift that does not build that sense of capability can actually widen the gap.

The same pattern appears in a 2025 scoping review of 110 studies on digital tools for family care (SSPH+ / *Public Health Reviews*). The review found that technology can reduce caregiver burden and improve competence, but only when it is usable and accessible. When it is not — when it adds complexity, requires constant troubleshooting, or creates privacy or security concerns — it increases burden instead.

The barriers to helpful technology are consistent across studies: limited digital literacy, technical problems, poor accessibility, and data-security worries (JMIR Aging, 2026; SSPH+, 2025). A gift that does not address those barriers is a gift that sits unused or becomes a source of friction.

### 4. What a successful gift looks like

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A successful technology gift for an older adult does three things:

- **It removes the "adapt to the tool" problem.** The interface, pacing, and language are designed for older learners from the start, not simplified after the fact.
- **It builds self-efficacy, not just access.** Confidence is the strongest predictor of whether an older learner persists. Age-appropriate, self-paced training has been shown in randomized controlled research to significantly improve attitudes and self-efficacy (Laganà et al.).

- **It respects the caregiver's role without making the caregiver the product.** The recipient can learn and redeem the gift on their own, but the design is calm enough that the caregiver does not need to become the daily help desk.

A 2026 scoping review in *JMIR Aging* of app-based interventions for family caregivers of older adults identified 49 studies and 44 unique applications. The most useful designs were those that supported caregiver well-being and reduced burden — not by adding features, but by being well designed and carefully evaluated. The quality of the design and the evidence behind it mattered more than the number of features.

## 5. The mynaani gift: what you are giving

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When you give mynaani, you are giving access to a curriculum and an interface built for adults 55 and older.

- **Plain-language AI literacy** — one step at a time, with no tests, grades, or timers.
- **Cognitively-protective design** — readable type, stable layouts, high contrast, and no pressure patterns.
- **Reversibility and self-pacing** — the recipient can stop, return, and repeat without penalty or confusion.
- **No subscription trap** — a one-time gift purchase; the recipient will not be charged again.
- **Redemption on their own schedule** — the gift code is sent to you; you share it when they are ready.

You are not giving another device to manage or another app to troubleshoot. You are giving the older adult a structured, respectful path to learn AI on their own terms — and, over time, to rely on you less for the next new tool.

## 6. How to give it well

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Research on older adults and family support suggests a few practical principles:

- **Offer, do not install.** Let the recipient choose when and whether to redeem the gift. Agency matters.
- **Match their self-view.** Express confidence in their ability to learn, but do not oversell. The Heliyon research suggests that alignment between your expectations and theirs is more important than high expectations alone.
- **Stay available, not indispensable.** Be willing to help with redemption, then let the curriculum do the teaching. The goal is their independence, not a new shared project.
- **Protect them from urgency.** Avoid pressure, deadlines, or guilt. Older adults learn best in low-stakes, predictable environments.

## 7. Conclusion and next step

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The AI gap is not only an institutional problem. For most older adults, it is lived at home, in the questions they ask a family member, and in the tools they quietly stop using because the effort is too high. A technology gift that respects how they learn can change that arc — but only if the gift is designed for the learner, not for the giver.

Mynaani's gift purchase is a one-time, secure checkout. The gift code comes to your email; the recipient redeems it when they are ready. If you have questions about whether mynaani is the right fit for the person you care about, write to [hello@mynaani.com](mailto:hello@mynaani.com).

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## About mynaani

Mynaani is an AI learning program designed specifically for adults 55+, built on geragogical principles and a patent-pending cognitively-protective interface. We have an interest in the conclusion of this brief; readers should weigh it accordingly. Every statistic cited is third-party and verifiable below.

## References

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